

Describe the Scene

DIFFICULT PRACTICE

— No plot, no characters, no dialogue this time — just the place itself, built entirely out of the words you choose.

Name: _____ Date set: _____ Due: _____

CHOOSE ONE OF THE FOLLOWING

1. Describe a busy railway station at the exact moment the last train of the night pulls in.
2. Describe an abandoned playground the morning after a storm.

This is a different skill from a story. Don't invent a plot or name any characters — you're painting a picture with words, not telling us what happens. A reader should be able to picture the place clearly and feel something about it, without anyone in it doing anything.

TECHNIQUE REQUIRED

BUILD THE PICTURE

Appeal to at least **4 of the 5 senses** — not just what it looks like.

2 similes and **1 metaphor**, each comparing to something that actually suits the mood of the scene.

1 example of personification — give something non-living a human quality or action.

Vary your sentence lengths — include at least one very short sentence (one or two words) for impact.

2 semicolons and **1 colon**, used naturally.

Shape: start wide (the whole scene) → zoom into 2–3 specific details → end on one lasting image or feeling.

YOUR WRITING

Checklist — go over it again

1. **Read it all out loud** — does it actually sound like a real place?
2. **No clichés** — check for overused phrases ("as quiet as a mouse," "the calm before the storm") and replace with your own image.
3. Every simile or metaphor compares to something that fits the mood — not just something that rhymes or sounds clever.
4. Was / were — check it matches a singular or plural subject.
5. Every sentence has a verb, except your deliberate one- or two-word sentences.
6. No word repeated in the same sentence or the one right after it — swap for a synonym.
7. **Ending leaves one lasting image** — don't summarise ("Overall, the station was busy") or trail off.